When India assumed the G20 presidency late last year, the world was already in a state of deep disorder. It was, in fact, in free fall as a war provoked by Russia's invasion of Ukraine—now in its 19th month—saw big powers line up dangerously against each other. This was immediately after the Covid-19 pandemic had gutted not just lives but even the economies of nations, intensifying a process of deglobalisation that had begun over a decade ago. As nation after nation, including the United States, grew more insular and protectionist in their economic outlook, it exacerbated global fault lines. So much so that the so-called Washington Consensus, adopted by multilateral institutions such as the IMF and the World Bank in the 1980s to fund global debt by pushing for free markets, privatisation and globalisation of economies, was all but buried. Meanwhile, China, under Xi Jinping, aggressively pushed for superpower status, challenging American hegemony. The country also triggered a border confrontation with India, its worst in 50 years, overturning three decades of confidence-building measures, painstakingly crafted precisely to prevent such an escalation.

It was in this troubled milieu that India took the leadership of the G20, the world's most powerful grouping of nations, and hoped to lay the foundation of a new world order that would be far more inclusive, harmonious and compassionate. The slogan India adopted was aspirational but relevant: One Earth, One Family, One Future. Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's helmsmanship, the G20 rollout was turned into a national movement, with 200-plus meetings in some 60 venues across the country. Modi personally supervised the remodelling of Delhi's Pragati Maidan into the Bharat Mandapam, which was achieved with record speed. What it has resulted in is a conference venue that is state-of-the-art but which also showcases India's rich heritage. New Delhi was locked down for three days to ensure both the security and ease of movement of the 30 heads of state who attended the summit, in addition to hundreds of delegates. The moment of truth had truly arrived on September 9 as the leaders assembled to give consent to the key outcomes that its representatives had hammered out in various working groups on issues ranging from tackling global indebtedness, eradicating poverty worldwide, giving a huge push to climate change initiatives to the return to a rules-based international order.

The grouping itself had emerged out of the 1999 Asian financial crisis when the finance ministers and governors of central banks met to discuss global economic and financial issues. Nine years later, when the collapse of Lehman Brothers precipitated another global financial crisis in 2008, it was upgraded to a summit level that went beyond the economic and finance mandate to address geopolitical issues too. This led to the emergence of two clear tracks: the first of finance ministers who would discuss issues such as ensuring that the international financial architecture was stable, secure and inclusive, and the role multilateral development banks (MDBs) could play in easing global debt besides providing sustainable finance for infrastructure and climate change. The other was the sherpa track that had 13 working groups spanning the entire gamut of key international issues, from development, agriculture, education, health, employment, environment and disaster management to anti-corruption. It would always be a difficult ask to get meaningful outcomes on such humongous and diverse issues. India's G20 presidency got even tougher with the complex interplay of the big power geopolitics that threatened to rain on its parade.

PLAYING CHINESE CHECKERS

If India was hoping for full attendance of the G20 heads of state, it was in for some disappointment. Chief among the absentees was Chinese president Xi Jinping and his Russian counterpart Vladimir Putin, both answering to different geopolitical reasons. Mexican president Andres Manuel Lopez Obrador stayed away too, making it the fourth consecutive physical G20 summit that the Mexican head of state would skip. Russia stayed away for Bali in 2022 and Rome in 2021, following its invasion of Ukraine. Xi



UNITED COLOURS OF BHARAT PM Narendra Modi at the inauguration of the Bharat Mandapam at Pragati Maidan, July 26